

Missouri - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-25 caliber SEC team with a legitimate defensive foundation, an elite returning running-back ceiling and a strong tackle/TE core.
Preseason consensus	No. 25 (117 points) · SEC No. 10 (1105 points) · No. 19
Returning production	53% (No. 66) overall · Off. 59% (No. 49) · Def. 46% (No. 87)
Primer power rating	+15.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.3 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ - Similar overall quality, but more volatile and less proven on defense
Confidence	Medium

2026 identity: Missouri should be a downhill-run offense under new OC/play-caller Chip Lindsey, using the run game and TE Brett Norfleet to create explosives/downfield opportunities for named QB Austin Simmons.

Bottom line: Missouri has enough line talent, run-game upside and defensive structure to stay in the Top-25/upper-middle SEC tier, but its season is more fragile than the No. 19 SP+ rank because Hardy's return timeline, a new quarterback/offensive system and heavy defensive replacement load all matter before a brutal second-half schedule.

Beats expectations if: RB Ahmad Hardy returns quickly after missing the opener, QB Austin Simmons gives OC Chip Lindsey competent downfield passing off the run game, and the rebuilt defense preserves most of its 2025 disruption.

Disappoints if: RB Ahmad Hardy's absence lingers, the new QB/OC pairing cannot punish loaded boxes, and heavy defensive turnover shows up in the secondary or second level.

Five things to remember

- 2025 baseline:** Missouri's 2025 defense was legitimately elite by several measures: No. 10 in success rate allowed, No. 10 in havoc created, No. 16 in EPA/play allowed and No. 18 in adjusted defense.
- Coaching:** QB Austin Simmons is the named starter, and new OC Chip Lindsey is the offensive play-caller.
- ★ **RB Ahmad Hardy:** RB Ahmad Hardy is an All-America 1,649-yard returning star, but he has been ruled out for the season opener while recovering from the May gunshot wound.
- NFL departures:** Defensive returning production is only 46% (No. 87), matching a personnel ledger with six NFL draft picks plus multiple additional professional departures.
- Schedule pressure:** The schedule is a major limiter: SP+ SOS is No. 15, and the final four games include Texas, at Georgia and Oklahoma.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	8-5 (4-4 SEC)	● Good
Scoring	30.2 PPG	● Good / above average
Total offense	416.3 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	228.3 YPG · 5.3 YPC	● Elite
Pass efficiency	6.75 YPA · 15 TD / 11 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	44.9%	● Very good
Scoring defense	18.9 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	277.3 YPG allowed	● Elite
Rush defense	103.8 YPG · 3.2 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	173.5 YPG · 5.95 YPA · 15 TD allowed	● Very good

Missouri played like a better underlying team than a generic five-loss profile.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.02 · No. 34	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.066 · No. 42	● Good / above average
Off. success rate	46.8% · No. 33	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	13.4% · No. 35	● Very good
Havoc allowed	12.0% · No. 18	● Very good
Opp.-adjusted defense	+6.88 · No. 18	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.139 · No. 16	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	34.7% · No. 10	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	9.4% · No. 18	● Very good
Havoc created	19.2% · No. 10	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: Missouri's 2025 defense was not a mirage: total defense ranked No. 8, adjusted defense No. 18, EPA/play allowed No. 16, success rate allowed No. 10, explosive-play prevention No. 18 and havoc No. 10.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Eli Drinkwitz - returning	● ↔ Program continuity remains a stabilizer while the offense changes coordinators and quarterbacks.
OC / offensive play-caller	◆ Chip Lindsey - new external	● ↔ New coordinator creates transition risk.
DC	Corey Batoon - returning	● ↔ Returns after a genuinely elite-efficiency 2025 defense.
Co-DC / LB	◆ Derek Nicholson - internal promotion	● ↔ Internal promotion preserves linebacker-room/system continuity while adding formal co-coordinator responsibility.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Austin Simmons	Ole Miss	● ↔ Named starting QB gives the offense role certainty, but Missouri-specific production is still unproven.
◆ WR Cayden Lee	Ole Miss	● ↔ Major outside receiving candidate who helps replace WR Kevin Coleman Jr.
◆ OT Luke Work	Mississippi State	● ↑ Projected starting right tackle fills a high-leverage role opposite OT Cayden Green.

Out	To	Loss
WR Kevin Coleman Jr.	NFL (Miami), Round 5, No. 177	● ↓ Leading 2025 receiver leaves for the NFL, creating the clearest pass-catcher replacement burden.
OL Keagen Trost	NFL (L.A. Rams), Round 3, No. 93	● ↓ Starting OL departure removes proven line continuity despite strong returning tackle pieces.
C Connor Tollison	San Francisco 49ers rookie minicamp invite	● ↓ Veteran starting center exits for a rookie-minicamp opportunity.
QB Beau Pribula	Virginia	● ↔ Quarterback-room turnover is composition-significant, but QB Simmons is now the named starter.

Offensive net: ● ↔ Roughly similar but more volatile: the line/run-game core is strong.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Robert Woodyard Jr.	Auburn	● ↑ All-SEC-recognized linebacker is a direct high-leverage answer to major second-level departures.
◆ CB Chris Graves Jr.	Ole Miss	● ↔ Experienced corner is a major candidate in a secondary replacing multiple professional departures.
◆ CB Sione Laulea	Oregon	● ↔ Major outside-corner candidate with the same replacement mandate.
◆ S JaDon Blair	Notre Dame	● ↔ Significant safety candidate after extensive back-end losses.

Out	To	Loss
DE Zion Young	NFL (Baltimore), Round 2, No. 45	● ↓ Second-round edge departure removes a major pressure/disruption piece.
LB Josiah Trotter	NFL (Tampa Bay), Round 2, No. 46	● ↓ Another second-round linebacker departure is one of multiple high-leverage second-level losses.
DT Chris McClellan	NFL (Green Bay), Round 3, No. 77	● ↓ Third-round interior defender leaves a front that now leans on DT Webb/Gracial and transfers.
CB Toriano Pride Jr.	NFL (Buffalo), Round 7, No. 220	● ↓ Meaningful corner leaves for the NFL as the secondary shifts to transfer replacements.
S/STAR Daylan Carnell	NFL (Pittsburgh Steelers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Long-term starting STAR/safety loss increases communication demands in the rebuilt secondary.

Defensive net: ● ↔ Down in continuity and proven depth.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Lindsey has explicitly described a downhill-run-first offense that uses the run game to create explosives.	RB Hardy/Roberts give the run game star-plus-depth quality.	QB Simmons must punish loaded boxes and replace enough passing production.
Defense	Batoon continuity should preserve the disruptive, efficient structure that produced elite 2025 success-rate/havoc results.	A strong interior rotation led by DT Webb/Gracial, Woodyard at linebacker and multiple experienced transfer corners.	Professional departures hit every level.
Special teams	Rebuilt kicking operation after Meyer's transfer.	Craig is back on the roster and Shenouda is a punter candidate.	The final specialist order remains open and SP+ rates the unit No. 118.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B-	● ↔	Medium	QB Austin Simmons is the named starter in new OC Chip Lindsey's offense.
RB	● A-	● ↔	Medium-low	RB Ahmad Hardy returns after 1,649 yards with All-America recognition but will miss the opener; RB Jamal Roberts becomes more important immediately.
WR	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Cayden Lee and other returning/new options must replace 2025 leader WR Kevin Coleman Jr.
TE	● B+	● ↑	Medium-high	TE Brett Norfleet returns with Mackey recognition and a larger role in the new offense.
OL	● B+	● ↔	Medium	OT Cayden Green anchors a line that still has unsettled pieces around him.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	DT Sterling Webb and returning/transfer depth keep the front viable despite material departures.
LB	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	LB Robert Woodyard Jr./LB Josiah Rodriguez must replace major losses led by LB Josiah Trotter.
Secondary	● B-	● ↓	Low	CB Chris Graves Jr./CB Laulea/CB Florence/S Blair form a talented but heavily rebuilt secondary.
Special teams	● C	● ↓	Low	SP+ ranks the rebuilt specialist unit No. 118 with the final order unsettled.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	HC Eli Drinkwitz/DC Corey Batoon provide continuity; OC Chip Lindsey is the new play-caller.
Overall	● B+	● ↔	Medium	A +15.5 primer rating fits a strong top-25 roster with a proven 2025 defensive foundation.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Ahmad Hardy	RB	● National star / offensive centerpiece	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team	1,649-yard 2025 rusher with the highest ceiling on the roster; ruled out for the opener while recovering.
Cayden Green	OT	● National star / elite tackle	AP 2nd team · SEC Coaches 1st team · SEC Media 1st team · Outland Trophy	The most proven offensive line anchor.
◆ Austin Simmons (TR: Ole Miss)	QB	● Above-average Power 4 starter projection / key unknown	-	Named starter under a new play-caller.
Brett Norfleet	TE	● High-end conference starter	John Mackey Award	Returning recognized TE with an explicitly expanded schematic role in Lindsey's offense.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
♦ Robert Woodyard Jr. (TR: Auburn)	LB	● High-upside conference starter	SEC Coaches 3rd team	Most recognized incoming second-level replacement after multiple professional linebacker departures.
Sterling Webb	DT	● Solid/high-end conference starter when eligible	-	Eight-start 2025 interior defender returned to the roster under court relief.
♦ Cayden Lee (TR: Ole Miss)	WR	● Major outside receiving starter candidate	-	Ole Miss transfer is one of the primary answers to WR Kevin Coleman Jr.'s NFL departure.
♦ Chris Graves Jr. (TR: Ole Miss)	CB	● Major starting-corner candidate	-	Experienced transfer whose assimilation is central to replacing multiple NFL-bound defensive backs.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Very difficult: Missouri gets manageable September opportunities, then faces six project opponents ranked in the SP+ top 20, including Texas.
Difficulty	● 9/10 · SP+ SOS No. 15
Hardest stretch	Texas -> at Georgia -> Kentucky -> Oklahoma
Swing games	Florida, Texas A&M, at Ole Miss, Oklahoma
Advantage	The opener and Troy are at home, and Missouri reaches the late-season Texas/Georgia/Oklahoma gauntlet after an Oct.24 bye and a road game at Arkansas.
Expected	7.3 wins · likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The Top-25 label and RB Hardy star power can create public optimism, but the SEC poll (No. 10) and brutal schedule correctly signal that Missouri is a strong team with limited margin for roster-replacement mistakes.
Back them when	The price discounts Missouri because of the prior record rather than the 2025 efficiency profile.
Fade/pass when	The opponent can force obvious passing downs.
Key monitor	RB Ahmad Hardy return timeline after the opener, DT Sterling Webb eligibility/legal status, final OL five, secondary combinations, kicker/punter order after Robert Meyer departure
Week 1 baseline	vs. Arkansas-Pine Bluff: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Missouri -54.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Missouri remains a credible top-25 team because the 2025 defense was elite by success rate/havoc and the offense still has premium anchors in RB Ahmad Hardy, OT Cayden Green and TE Brett Norfleet around named QB Austin Simmons. Hardy's confirmed opener absence temporarily shifts more early burden to the rest of that skill group.

The risk is concentrated in availability and replacement volume: RB Hardy will miss the opener and his return timing beyond it matters, defensive returning production is only **46%**, and the schedule closes with a difficult SEC run. That supports the **7.3-win / 7-5** baseline despite strong underlying quality.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

© 2026 DRWhittier. Original analysis, commentary, selection, and arrangement.

Sources: [camp update](#) · [camp update](#) · [preseason honors](#) · [QB update](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [2026 roster](#) · [2026 roster](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [ABC17/KMIZ report](#) · [camp update](#)

Last updated: August 25, 2026